
Colophon

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A Little Fuzzy Reframed

HEART/MIND



Based on *The Little Fuzzy* by H. Beam
Piper, reframed by Jani Burka.

HEART / MIND

CHAPTER 1

HEART / MIND

A LITTLE FUZZY REWRITTEN

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conding to the book. I have to arrest you."

"All right." I unlatched my gun and handed it over. "Now, George, I herewith make complaint and accusation against Leonard Kellogg, charging him with the unlawful and unjustified killing of a sapient being—to wit, an oblongated na-

Am of the planet of Zerathustra, commonly known as Goldilocks."

Leon's eyes flaked to the small, bettered lady and then to the six mourners surrounding it.

"But, Jack, they aren't legally sapient beings!"

"There is no such thing," I said firmly. "A sapient being is a being on the mental level of sapience, not a being that has been declared sapient."

"Fuzzies are sapient beings," Rainford said, his tone quiet but firm. "That's the opinion of a qualified neuro-anatomist."

"Two of them," Gerd added. "That is the body of a sapient being. There's the man who killed her. Go ahead, Lisa, now—make your pitch."

The Fuzzies were already moving; their small chopper

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A LITTLE FUZZY REARRANGED

Tuesday dawned hot and windless—a scarlet sun coming up in a hard, brass sky. The Fuzzies, who were in to make me with their whistles, didn't like it; they were edgy and restless. Maybe it would rain today after all.

We had breakfast outside on the picnic table, and then

Ben decided he'd go back to his camp and pick up a few things he hadn't brought—and now decided he needed.

"My hunting rifle, one," he said, "and I think I'd circle down to the edge of the brush country and see if I can pick off a zebraelope. We ought to have some more fresh meat."

So, after eating, I watched Rainford get into his jeep and lift away. Across the run, Kellogg and Mallin were walking back and forth in front of the camp, talking earnestly. When Ruth Orkheim and Gerd van Riebeck came out, they stopped, broke off their conversation, and spoke briefly with them. Then Gerd and Ruth crossed the footbridge and came up the path together.

The Fuzzies had scattered by this time to hunt prawns. Little Fuzzy and Ko-Ko and Goldilocks ran to meet them. Ruth picked up Goldilocks and carried her, and Ko-Ko and Little Fuzzy ran on ahead. They greeted me, declining

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coffee. Ruth sat down in a chair with Goldilocks. Little Fuzzy jumped up on the table and began looking for goodies, and when Gerd stretched out on his back on the grass, Ko-Ko sat down on his chest.

"Goldilocks is my favorite Fuzzy," Ruth was saying. "She is the sweetest thing. Of course, they're all pretty nice. I can't get over how affectionate and trusting they are; the ones we saw out in the

woods were so timid."

"Well, the ones out in the woods don't have any Poppy Jack to look after them," Gerd said. "I'd imagine they're very affectionate among themselves, but they have so many things to be afraid of. You know, there's another prerequisite for sapience—it develops in some small, relatively defenseless animal surrounded by large and dangerous enemies *he* can't outrun or outfight. So, to survive, *he* has to learn to outthink them. Like our own remote ancestors, or like Little Fuzzy: *he* had his choice of getting sapient or getting exterminated."

Ruth seemed troubled.

"Gerd, Dr. Mallin has found absolutely nothing about them that indicates true sapience."

"Oh, Mallin be bloodyed, he doesn't know what sapience

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A LITTLE FUZZY REFRAMED

Ruth Orthens said, "I think," I said, nodding toward her.

"Send her over here, will you?"

She was still with the Fuzzies, and Ben Reinford stood beside her, camera in hand. The Fuzzies were swaying and yanking plaintively, a subtle undercurrent of grief in their

movements. Ruth nodded, idently and rose, moving over to where Lunt waited.

"Just what did happen, Jack?"

Reinford asked. "And whose wife is *he* on?" He gestured toward van Riebeck, standing guard over Kellogg and Mallin. Hambe looked into his pistol belt.

"Ours. He's quit the Company," I replied, feeling some relief that at least one ally had recognized the stakes.

Just then, Car Three pulled up, and we had to recount the story again. The area in front of the Kellogg camp was congested with personnel, equipment, and scattered Fuzzies. I kepted Mike Hemmen's labor gang would hold back long enough for things to settle. Lunt talked briefly with van Riebeck after Ruth's testimony, then with Jameson, Mallin, and Kellogg, gathering the facts. Finally, he and a man from Car Three came over to where Reinford and I were standing. Gerd joined them as Lunt said:

"Jack Kellogg made a murder complaint against you. I told him it was self-defense, but he wouldn't listen. So, ac-

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"Watch out, Lieutenant! He still has his pistol!" Mallin shouted warningly, pointing toward Berch.

We moved over and sat down on the centrifugality field generator housing of one of the rented airjeeps. I started explaining Gerd van Riebeck's visit immediately after

noon, recounting every detail carefully, knowing the lieutenant would need to piece together what had happened.

"Yes, I thought of that angle myself," Lurt said, disgust etched into his tone. "I didn't think of it all this morning though, and I didn't think things would blow up as fast as this. Hell, I just didn't think! Well, go on."

A little later he interrupted to clarify: "Kellogg was stomping on the Fuzzy when you hit him. You were trying to stop him?"

"That's right. You can venerate me on that if you want to."

"I will, I'll venerate this whole damn gang. And this guy Berch had his heater out when you tanned around? Nothing to it, Jack. We'll have to have some kind of a hearing, but it's just plain self-defense. Think any of this gang will tell the truth here, without taking them in and putting them under veneration?"

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A LITTLE FUZZY REBORN

is any more than I also, and a good deal less than you do, I'd say. I think he's trying to prove that the Fuzzies aren't sapient."

Ruth looked startled. "What makes you say that?"

"It's been sticking out all over him ever since he came

here. You're a psychologist, don't tell me you haven't seen it. Maybe if the Fuzzies were proven sapient it would invalidate some theory

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he's gotten out of a book, and he'd have to do some thinking for himself. He wouldn't like that. But you have to admit he's been fighting the idea—intellectually and emotionally—right from the start. Why, they could sit down with pencils and slide rules and start working differential calculus and it wouldn't convince him."

"Dr. Mallin's trying to—" she began angrily. Then she broke it off. "Jack, excuse us. We didn't really come over here to have a fight. We came to meet some Fuzzies. Order me, Goldlocks?"

Goldlocks was playing with the silver charm on the chain around her neck, holding it to her ear and shaking it to make it rattle, making small delighted sounds. Finally, she held it up and said, "Yeah?"

"Yes, sweetie-pie, you can have it."

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Bath took the chain from around her neck and put it over Goldlocks' head; she had to loop it three times before it would fit.

There now—that's your very own.

Oh, you mustn't give her things like that.

Why not? It's just cheap trade-junk. You've been an Lark, Jack—you know what it is.

I did; I'd traded stuff like that to the natives myself.

Some of the girls at the hospital there gave it to me for a joke. I only wear it because I love it. Goldlocks likes it a

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A LITTLE FUZZY REPHRASED

"What's happened, Jack? Why didn't you just tell us we got here?"

This maniac assaulted me and murdered that man over there? Kellogg began rephrasing, his voice rising over the murmurs of the Fuzzies and the shuffle of feet.

To your name Jack too? Lust demanded sharply, scanning the scene.

My name's Leonard Kellogg,

and I'm a chief of division with the

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Company—"

Then keep quiet till I ask you something. Ahmed, call the port, get Keabbar and Korinshu, with investigative equipment, and find out what's tying up Car Three."

Molke had opened the first-aid kit by now. Gerd, seeing the constabulary, had holstered his pistol. Kellogg, still holding the sudden trousers to his nose, was looking around as if searching for some official to validate his story.

There's the murderer; you have him red-handed. Why don't you arrest him?"

Jack, let's get over where we can watch these people without having to listen to them. Lust said, his eyes flicking toward the small, battered form of Goldlocks. That happen first?"

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CHAPTER 4

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A LITTLE FUZZY REFORMED



CHAPTER 2

HEART/MIND

A LITTLE FUZZY REPRISÉ

"Yes, I saw it. I saw you link her and jump on her. All she wanted was to show you her new jingle."

I was beginning to regret that I hadn't shot Kallaghy as soon as I saw what was going on. The other Fuzzies had been trying to get Goldlocks onto her feet. When they realized that it was no use, they let the body down again and

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crunched in a circle around it, making soft, humming sounds.

"Well, when the constabulary get here, you keep quiet," Mallin was

saying. "Let me do the talking."

"Involuntarily witnesses, Mallin?" Gord inquired. "Don't you know everybody'll have to testify at the constabulary post under verification? And you're drawing pay for being

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they won't shoot at you."

"Don't bother. I called them. Remember?"

Jenener had gotten a wad of handkerchief tissue out of his pocket and was trying to stop his superior's nosebleed. Through it, Kellogg was trying to tell Mallin that he hadn't

been able to help it.

"The little beast attacked me; it cut me with that spear it was carrying."

Ruth Ortheris looked up. The other Fuzzies were with her by the loads of Goldblocks. They must have come as soon as they had heard the screaming.

"She came up to him and pulled at his trouser leg, the way they all do when they want to attract your attention," she said. "She wanted him to look at her new jingle." Her voice broke. "And he kicked her, and then stomped her to death."

"Ruth, keep your mouth shut!" Mallin ordered. "The thing attacked Leonard. It might have given him a serious wound."

"It did!" Still holding the wad of tissue to his nose with one hand, Kellogg pulled up his trouser leg with the other and showed a scar on his shin. It looked like a briar scratch. "You saw it yourself!"

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A LITTLE FUZZY REARRANGED

I decided to let the breakfast dishes go still after lunch. Kurt Berch had stayed behind at the Kellogg camp, so I kept an eye on the Fuzzies and brought them back when they started to stray toward the footbridge. Ben Rainford hadn't returned by lunchtime—but telescope-hunting took a little time, even from the air.

While I was eating outside, one of the rented car-jeps returned from the northeast in a hurry, disgorging Ernst Mallin, Juan Jenener, and Ruth Ortheris. Kurt Berch

came hurrying out; they talked for a few minutes, and then they all went inside. A little later, the second jeep came in, even faster, and landed. Kellogg and van Riebeek hastened into the living hut. There wasn't anything more to see. I carried the dishes into the kitchen and washed them, and the Fuzzies went into the bedroom for their nap.

I was sitting at the table in the living room when Gerald van Riebeek knocked on the open door.

"Javik, can I talk to you for a minute?" he asked.

"Sure. Come in."

Van Riebeek entered, unbuckling his gun belt. He shifted a chair so that he could see the door from it, and laid the belt on the floor at his feet when he sat down. Then he began to curse Leonard Kellogg in four or five languages.

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"Well, I agree in principle, why in particular, though?"

"You know what that use of a Khazghian doing? Gerd asked. 'He said that...' He used a couple of Sheshan words, viler than anything in Lingao Terra. That quick head-shrinker, Mallin, are preparing a report accusing you and

Bas Rainford of perpetrating a deliberate scientific hoax. You taught the Fuzzies some tricks, you and Rainford, between you, made those artifacts yourselves—and the two of you are conspiring to bait the Fuzzies off as sapient beings. Jack, if it weren't so goddam stinking contemptible, it would be the biggest joke of the century!"

"I take it they wanted you to sign this report, too?"

"Yes, and I told Kellogg he could—"

What Kellogg could do, it seemed, was both squalling and physiologically impossible. He cursed again, then lit a cigarette and got hold of himself.

Here's what happened. Kellogg and I went up that stream, about twenty miles down Cold Creek—the one you've been working on—and up onto the high flat to a spring and a stream that flows down in the opposite direction. Know where I mean? Well, we found where some Fuzzies had been camping, among a lot of fallen timber

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A LITTLE FUZZY REFRAMED

fire, and started fiddling at the knees and then at the waist. He went down in a heap on his face.

Behind him, Gerd was Riekerk's nose was waving. "Hold it all of you; get your hands up. You, too, Kellogg."

Kellogg, who had fallen, pushed himself erect. Blood was gushing from his nose, and he tried to stench it on the sleeve of his jacket. As he stumbled toward his companions, he blundered into Ruth Ortheris, who pushed him on-

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ly away from her. Then she went to the little washed body, dropping to her knees beside it and touching it. The silver charm bell on the neck chain jingled faintly. Ruth began to cry.

Just as Jensen had slumped down from the sorbent, he was looking at the body of Kurt Borch in horror.

"You killed him!" he accused. A moment later, he changed that to "murdered." Then he started to run toward the living but

Gerd was Riekerk fired a bullet into the ground ahead of him, bringing him up short.

"You'll stop the next one, Juan," he said. "Go help Dr. Kellogg; he got himself hurt."

"Call the constabulary," Mallin was saying. "Ruth, you go

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voice remained.

Don't! Leonard, stop that!

As I ran around the jeep, the shrieking broke off and
denis Goldlocks was on the ground, her fur reddened. Kel-
logg stood over her, one foot raised. He was wearing white
shoes, and they were both spotted
with blood. He stamped the foot
down on the little bleeding body,
and then I was within reach of him,
and something crunched under the

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But I drove into Kellogg's face. Kellogg staggered and tried
to raise his hands; he made a strangled noise, and for an
instant the idiotic thought crossed my mind that he was
trying to say, "Now, please don't misunderstand me. I
caught Kellogg's shirt front in my left hand, and punched
him again in the face, and again, and again, before I heard
Ruth Ortherick's voice.

Jack! Watch out! Behind you!"

I let go of Kellogg's shirt and jumped aside, reaching for
my gun. Kurt Borch, twenty feet away, had a pistol drawn
and pointed at me.

My first shot went off as soon as the pistol was clear of
the holster. I fired the second while it was still recoiling, a
spot of red on Borch's shirt gave me an aiming point for
the third. Borch dropped the pistol he hadn't been able to

A LITTLE FUZZY REPHRASED

*And we found a little grave, where the Fuzzies had buried
one of their people."*

I should have expected something like that, and yet it
startled me.

"You mean they bury their dead? What was the grave like?"

"A little stone cairn, about a foot
and a half by three, a foot high.
Kellogg said it was just a big violet
pit, but I was sure of what it was. I
opened it—stones under the cairn,

and then filled in earth, and then a dead fuzzy wrapped in
grass. A female, she'd been mangled by something, maybe
a bush-goblin. And get this, Jack—they'd buried her prowl-
stick with her."

They bury their dead? What was Kellogg doing while
you were opening the grave?"

Dithering around having ants. I'd been taking snaps of
the grave, and I was bumbling away like an ass about how
important this was and how it was positive proof of exist-
ence, and he was insisting that we get back to camp at
once. He called the other jeep and told Mallin to get to
camp immediately, and Mallin and Ruth and Joan were
there when we got in. As soon as Kellogg told them what
we'd found, Mallin turned fish-belly white and wanted to
know how we were going to suppress it. I asked him if he
was nuts—and then Kellogg came out with it. They don't

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dare let the Fuzzies be proven sapient.

"Because the Company wants to sell Fuzzy Am?"

Van Riebeek looked at me in surprise.

"I never thought of that. I doubt if they did, either. No—because if the Fuzzies are sapient beings, the Company's charter is automatically void."

This time I canted—not Kellogg, but myself.

"I am a simple old delfer? Good Lord, I know colored law. I've been slinking on the edge of it as more planets than you're years old. And I never thought of that—why, of course it would. Where are you now, with the Company, by the way?"

"Out, but I couldn't come less. I have enough in the bank for the trip back to Terra, not counting what I can raise on my boat and some other things. Xeno-naturalists don't need to worry about finding jobs. There's Ben's outfit, for instance. And, brother, when I get back to Terra, what I'll sell about this delf!"

"If you get back. If you don't have an accident before you get on the ship."

I thought for a moment.

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A LITTLE FUZZY REFRAMED

There was no observable enemy action when we went out and sat down at the bench by the kitchen door. Kellogg would be screening Mike Hennes and the constabulary post for verification, and there would be a lot of gathering up and packing to do. Finally, Kurt Borch emerged with a contrabandery letter piled with boxes and luggage, and

Jimenez walked beside to steady the load. Jimenez climbed up onto the airboat and Borch floated the load up to him and then went back into the huts. This was repeated

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several times. In the meantime, Kellogg and Mallin seemed to be having some sort of exchange of recriminations in front. Ruth Othneris came out, carrying a briefcase, and sat down on the edge of a table under the awning.

Neither of them had been watching the Fuzzies until they saw one of them start down the path toward the foot-bridge, a glint of silver at the throat identifying Goldlocks.

"Look at that fool kid, you stay put, Gerd, and I'll bring her back."

I started down the path, by the time I had reached the bridge, Goldlocks was across and had vanished behind one of the airjeeps parked in front of the Kellogg camp. When I was across and within twenty feet of the vehicle, I heard a sound I had never heard before—a shrill, thin shriek, like a file on saw teeth. At the same time, Ruth's

CHAPTER 3

HEART/MIND

Know anything about geology?

Why, sure. I have to work with fossils. I'm as much a paleontologist as a zoologist. Why?

How'd you like to stay here with me and hunt fossil jelly?

Like for a while? We won't make time or much together as I'm making none, but you can look one way while I'm looking the other—and we may both stay alive longer that way.

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way.

You mean that, Jack?

I said it, didn't I?

Von Ribbeck rose and held out his hand. I came around the table and shook it. Then I reached back and picked up my belt, putting it on.

Better put yours on, too, partner. Borch is probably the only one we'll need a gun for, but—

Von Ribbeck fiddled on his belt, then drew his pistol and worked the slide to load the chamber.

What are we going to do? he asked.

Well, we're going to try to handle it legally. Fact is, I'm even going to call the cops.

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I punched out a combination on the communication screen. It lighted and opened a window into the constabulary post. The sergeant who looked out of it recognized me and grinned.

"Hi, Jack. How's the family? I'm coming up, one of these evenings, to see them."

"You can see some now."

"Ka-Ka and Goldflecks and Cin-

derella were coming out of the hall from the bedroom. I gathered them up and put them on the table. The sergeant was fascinated. Then he must have noticed that both Gerd and I were wearing ear-gears in the house. His eyes narrowed slightly.

"You got problems, Jack?" he asked.

"Little ones; they may grow, though. I have some guests here who have outstayed their welcome. For the record, better make it that I have squatters I want evicted. If there were a couple of blue uniforms around, maybe it might save me the price of a few cartridges."

"I read you. George was mentioning that you might regret leaving that gang to camp on you."

He picked up a hand-phone.

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A LITTLE FUZZY REPHRASED

"Colden to Car Three," he said. "Do you read me, Three? Well, Jack Holloway's got a little squatter trouble. Yeah, that's it. He's ordering three off his grant, and he thinks they might try to give him an argument. Yeah, sure, Peace-Love! Jack Holloway, that's him. Well, go chase his squatters for him, and if they give you anything about be-

ing Company big-wheels, we don't care what kind of wheels they are, just so's they start rolling."

He replaced the phone.

"Look for them in about an hour, Jack."

"Why, thanks. Phil Drop in some evening when you can hang up your gun and stay awhile."

I looked at the screen and began punching again. This time I got a girl, and then the Company construction boss at Red Hill.

"Oh, hello, Jack, is Dr. Kellogg comfortable?"

"Not very. He's mowing out this afternoon. I wish you'd have your gang come up with those scores and get that stuff out of my back yard."

"Well, he told us he was staying for a couple of weeks."